

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SECULAR GASTRONOMY

On the evening of April 18, shortly after landing in Delhi from Karnataka where he had been campaigning for the assembly polls, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi went to Matia Mahal market in Delhi's Chandni Chowk, and to Bengali Market near Connaught Place for a taste of street fare. Lest you think it was an impromptu visit by the Gandhi scion, looks like some political planning went into it. A few senior Congress leaders had proposed that Rahul host an iftaar in the month of Ramzan, like Sonia Gandhi would do in her time. Others voted against the idea, fearing it would invite charges of Muslim appeasement. As a compromise, Rahul went to Muslim-dominated Chandni Chowk where he could interact with the locals. And just so that he is not accused of religious bias, he also went to Bengali Market for some golgappas. Now that's what you call a balanced diet.

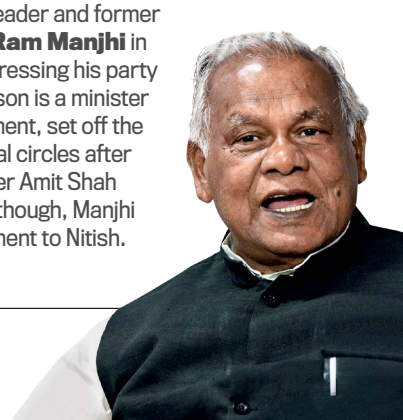


Netting the Electorate

The national high command may be busy with the upcoming Karnataka assembly election, but Gujarat BJP president **C.R. Paatil** has begun serious preparation for the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. His primary thrust is to connect with every voter digitally. At a training workshop for party members in Vadodara, he unequivocally stated that BJP workers should open as many social media accounts as possible to spread Prime Minister Narendra Modi's message. He also said that every panna pramukh must have the entire voters' list in the ward on his cellphone, complete with details of caste, profession, etc. Leaders should have an office that serve as a data centre of the voters in that area. No one covers their base like the BJP, or plans so much in advance.

PILOT BASIS

Whatever influence Sachin Pilot may or may not have in Rajasthan, he seems to have become an inspiration in distant Bihar. "If Sachin Pilot can protest against Ashok Gehlot, can Jitan Manjhi not do the same against Nitish Kumar?" asked Hindustani Awam Morcha leader and former Bihar chief minister **Jitan Ram Manjhi** in Patna on April 16, while addressing his party colleagues. Manjhi, whose son is a minister in the Nitish Kumar government, set off the rumour mills in Bihar political circles after meeting Union home minister Amit Shah on April 13. Despite all this, though, Manjhi claims his undying commitment to Nitish. Should Pilot take note?



THE BENGALI ID

Governor **C.V. Ananda Bose** turned up in kurta-pyjama and spoke in chaste Bangla at a cultural programme in Raj Bhawan on April 15 on the occasion of Poila Baisakh. However, he slightly modified the slogan of 'Jai Bangla', also the rallying cry of the ruling Trinamool Congress, to 'Jai Paschim Banga'. The BJP thinks West Bengal should retain its identity as Paschim Banga as it was carved out as a Hindu-majority state at Syama Prasad Mookerjee's insistence when undivided Bengal was partitioned. The battle lines for the 2024 Lok Sabha polls stand drawn—it will be Hindu pride vs Bangla pride.





Fraying Ties

On April 16, at the first executive committee meeting after **E.K. Palaniswami** took over as general secretary of the AIADMK, the mention of the party's alliance with the BJP was avoided in any of the 15 resolutions. Could it be because the association is seen to be weakening the AIADMK base among Muslims and Christians in Tamil Nadu? The party is peeved that Prime Minister Narendra Modi did not meet Palaniswami during his recent visit to Tamil Nadu and considers state BJP chief K. Annamalai's threat to reveal the AIADMK Files—a slew of corruption allegations against the party—as unfair. Is the alliance on the rocks?

Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Romita Datta, Amarnath K. Menon and Amitabh Srivastava